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Los Altos Hills to remove ALPR cameras

By Curtis Driscoll Staff Writer/curtisd@latc.com

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Los Altos Hills will not renew its automated license plate reader contract with Flock after it expires in June. It currently has 31 cameras, as seen in the map above.

Screenshot from Los Altos Hills Jan. 15 council meeting

						
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Los Altos Hills has decided to remove its Flock Safety automated license plate reader cameras around town, citing concerns about data privacy, cost considerations and overall effectiveness.

The City Council at its Jan. 15 meeting voted to direct city staff to begin the process of ending its contract with Flock Safety immediately for its 31 cameras around town.

The council removed the cameras due to concerns about Flock’s data privacy practices. These concerns related to U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) having indirect access to automated license plate reader cameras (ALPR) data through Flock network searches conducted by state and local police agencies, despite there being no direct contract between ICE and Flock, according to a city staff report. Flock maintains that local agencies have control over data and access. Los Altos Hills joins a growing movement of cities removing Flock cameras. The city of Santa Cruz is one of several cities, including Austin, Eugene and Denver, to pause or reevaluate Flock usage recently. Los Altos Hills’ contract with Flock began in 2021, and the current contract runs through June 30.

Los Altos Hills Mayor Rajiv Bhateja noted he pushed to get ALPR cameras into town to address skyrocketing burglaries at the time, but after several years of the ALPR program, he felt there were many limitations. Bhateja said he didn’t think the burglary rates had gone down because of Flock, instead giving more credit to private security. He also noted there were plenty of ways to get around Flock cameras, like freshly stolen or missing license plates, and felt money spent on Flock could go to other aspects of public safety. He also remained worried that data would not be protected, given the current political climate.

“I would come down to the side of acknowledging that we tried this experiment, and it didn’t work out the way we hoped,” Bhateja said. “I would rather take that money and deploy it to private security.”

The rest of the council agreed, with Councilmember Linda Swan voting to opt out of the contract over privacy concerns about information sharing. Councilmember Kavita Tankha felt the Flock cameras didn't prevent any crime, noting that people committing burglary were using stolen cars and license plates, which made it harder to trace, even with video surveillance. She believes private security was the biggest difference in bringing down burglary rates in the last two years. Burglaries have gone from 60 in 2023 to 20 in 2024 and 16 in 2025, according to city staff.

"I think what's happening is we are spending far too many dollars on the ALPR system combined with the amount we are paying the sheriff to monitor them, and I think those tax dollars could be used towards the additional officers that we need or having private security," Tankha said.

Costs for the public safety contract with the Santa Clara County Sheriff's Office are expected to rise in the coming years, a financial consideration to balance for public safety spending. The current cost for the ALPR cameras is \$93,000 a year. The council also directed staff to explore the possibility of being refunded a portion of the contract by Flock. Under the terms, Los Altos Hills pays the annual subscription up front. Cameras are expected to stop operating this month, with Flock working to remove the cameras and poles throughout town.

By Curtis Driscoll